



A WORLD FREE OF CHEMICAL WEAPONS

THE CHEMICAL WEAPONS CONVENTION (1993)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Arms control

BEFORE

1899, 1907 The Hague Conventions propose the international outlawing of chemical weapons.

1925 The Geneva Protocol proposes more enforceable prohibitions, but its impact is limited.

1975 The Biological Weapons Convention comes into force.

1990 An agreement between the US and the Soviet Union commits both to halting the production of new chemical weapons and to destroying stockpiled weapons.

AFTER

2013 Civil war breaks out in Syria. There are multiple chemical weapons attacks—including a sarin gas attack on a Damascus suburb that kills more than 1,400 civilians.

One of the most ambitious international treaties governing warfare, the Chemical Weapons Convention (CWC) aims to outlaw the use of these weapons everywhere. It was approved by the UN's General Assembly and made available for signature in 1993. By 2020, it had been ratified by 193 countries, and only three UN members—Egypt, South Sudan, and North Korea—were not party to it.

There is a long history of treaties to outlaw chemical weapons. The first was signed

in Strasbourg in 1675, when France and various German states agreed to ban “poisoned bullets.” More tellingly, in the Brussels Declaration of 1874, the Laws and Customs of War prohibited “poison or poisoned weapons.” Further restrictions were placed on the use of chemical weapons at the Hague Peace Conferences of 1899 and 1907.

Following the extensive use of chemical weapons in World War I, Germany was forbidden to use chemical weapons under the Treaty of Versailles. Then, in 1925, the Geneva Protocol outlawed the use

The **Chemical Weapons Convention (CWC)** adopts measures to **ban their use** in warfare.

The CWC **prohibits** all **manufacture and use** of any chemical weapons.

Nations must give access to **independent verifiers** to ensure destruction and decommissioning have been **carried out**.

It orders the **destruction** of existing chemical weapons and the **decommissioning** of all manufacturing facilities.